

1 ENGROSSED SENATE
2 BILL NO. 1778

By: Pugh of the Senate

3 and

4 Hilbert, Staires, and
5 Hasenbeck of the House

6 An Act relating to the Strong Readers Act; amending
7 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508A, as amended by
8 Section 3, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
9 2025, Section 1210.508A), which relates to the Strong
10 Readers Act; updating statutory reference; amending
11 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508B, as amended by
12 Section 4, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
13 2025, Section 1210.508B), which relates to
14 legislative intent; stating legislative intent
15 regarding a multi-tiered system of supports framework
16 and core literacy instruction; defining terms;
17 providing for promulgation of rules; amending 70 O.S.
18 2021, Section 1210.508C, as last amended by Section
19 2, Chapter 297, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025,
20 Section 1210.508C), which relates to assessments for
21 reading skills; modifying purpose of screening;
22 directing the Office of Educational Quality and
23 Accountability to evaluate and rank certain number of
24 screening instruments; directing the Commission for
Educational Quality and Accountability to approve
certain instruments; directing the State Board of
Education to select one screening instrument;
requiring the instrument to meet certain criteria;
removing language regarding requirements for a
program of reading instruction; directing use of
certain interventions; expanding students to be
provided certain reading intervention plan; adding
member to Student Reading Proficiency Teams; removing
language regarding certain notification of parents
and legal guardians; directing the State Board of
Education, in certain consultation, to annually
define and set certain benchmarks for screening
instrument results; directing the Office of
Educational Quality and Accountability to analyze and
report certain tiers; prohibiting reading
intervention from being provided solely by digital
technology; requiring reading intervention to include

1 certain amount of direct instruction; removing
2 language exempting certain school districts from
3 annually submitting strong readers plans; removing
4 language exempting certain students who demonstrate
5 proficiency on certain screening instrument from
6 programs of reading instruction; removing language
7 regarding intensive intervention services for certain
8 third-grade students; requiring certain first- and
9 second-grade students to be placed in certain
10 transitional classroom or provided certain
11 transitional instruction; requiring families of
12 certain first- and second-grade students to be
13 provided certain tutoring or summer reading options;
14 directing the State Department of Education to
15 approve certain tutoring programs; modifying
16 information to be included in certain notification
17 for parents and legal guardians; providing for
18 reading intervention services for certain incoming
19 third-grade students; requiring third-grade students
20 to demonstrate sufficient reading skills beginning in
21 certain school year; providing methods for
22 demonstration; requiring retention of certain third-
23 grade students; prohibiting screening instruments
24 from being used for promotion purposes; providing
good-cause exemptions to retention; providing good-
cause exemption request process; requiring written
notification of parents and legal guardians of
retained students; subjecting certain students to
certain screening and testing upon return to a public
school; prohibiting certain receiving school from
altering certain third-grade retention requirements
for a student who transfers; directing retained
students to be provided certain intervention
beginning in certain school year; requiring school
districts and the State Department of Education to
report certain information; updating statutory
language; updating statutory references; amending 70
O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508D, as amended by Section
6, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025,
Section 1210.508D), which relates to appropriated
funds designated for the Strong Readers Act; removing
language regarding calculation of certain allocation;
providing for calculation of base literacy
allocations; providing purpose of base literacy
allocation; providing for calculation of supplemental
weighted funding; providing purpose of supplemental
weighted funding; directing a portion of certain

1 funds to be provided as incentives for school
2 districts demonstrating certain improvement; amending
3 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508E, as amended by
4 Section 7, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
5 2025, Section 1210.508E), which relates to summer
6 academy programs; allowing a teacher to recommend
7 certain transitional setting or certain tutoring;
8 directing academy programs to incorporate certain
9 reading interventions and be taught by certain
10 individuals; requiring school districts to provide
11 certain intervention option to certain students;
12 requiring school districts to report certain
13 information to the State Board of Education; amending
14 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508F, as last amended by
15 Section 3, Chapter 297, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp.
16 2025, Section 1210.508F), which relates to reading
17 competencies for teacher education programs; allowing
18 professional development to include certain
19 components; requiring teacher candidates to study
20 certain negative impacts, identification of certain
21 models, and how to implement certain instruction;
22 requiring certain teacher education programs to be
23 audited for certain compliance; directing
24 noncompliant programs to be placed on certain status
and given certain guidance; amending Section 2,
Chapter 288, O.S.L. 2023, as amended by Section 9,
Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section
1210.508H), which relates to literacy instructional
teams; removing language limiting teams to certain
pilot program; directing the State Department of
Education to employ literacy coaches who are placed
in certain number of regions; providing duties of
coaches; providing for priority placement of coaches;
requiring coaches to pass certain test; increasing
number of coaches; providing additional criteria for
coaches; providing for assignment of coaches;
exempting a school district that employs certain
coaches from using certain literacy coaches;
requiring participation in certain coaching
improvement community; prohibiting certain school
districts that decline certain assistance from being
eligible to receive certain funding; requiring school
districts to have certain staff member at each
elementary school; directing the Office of
Educational Quality and Accountability, in certain
collaboration, to develop certain teacher training
academies to provide certain micro-credential;

1 providing certain stipend for receiving an early
2 literacy micro-credential; providing certain funding
3 amount for certain public and private institutions of
4 higher education; creating the Strong Readers
5 Revolving Fund; specifying sources of fund; providing
6 for expenditures; providing purpose of fund; allowing
7 donors to the fund to designate certain recipient;
8 providing for codification; and declaring an
9 emergency.

10 BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

11 SECTION 1. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508A,
12 as amended by Section 3, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
13 2025, Section 1210.508A), is amended to read as follows:

14 Section 1210.508A. Sections 1210.508A through ~~1210.508H~~
15 1210.508J of this title shall be known and may be cited as the
16 "Strong Readers Act".

17 SECTION 2. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508B,
18 as amended by Section 4, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
19 2025, Section 1210.508B), is amended to read as follows:

20 Section 1210.508B. A. The Legislature finds that it is
21 essential for children in the public schools to read early and well
22 in elementary school. The Legislature further finds that clear and
23 visible goals, assessments to determine the reading level at each
24 elementary school, use of a scientifically based and researched
methodology in reading instruction in addition to regular and
periodic measurements of elementary school reading improvement, and

1 accountability in each level of the educational system will result
2 in a significant increase in the number of children reading at or
3 above grade level.

4 B. The purpose of the Strong Readers Act is to ensure that
5 progression from one grade to another is determined, in part, upon
6 proficiency in reading, that school district board of education
7 policies facilitate reading instruction and intervention services to
8 address student reading needs, and that each student and his or her
9 parent or legal guardian be informed of that student's reading
10 progress. It is the intent of the Legislature that every student
11 reads at or above grade level by the end of third grade.

12 C. To carry out the purpose of this act, it is the intent of
13 the Legislature that the identification, instruction, and
14 intervention required under the Strong Readers Act be implemented
15 within a multi-tiered system of supports (MTSS) framework that
16 emphasizes strong core literacy instruction for all students and
17 provides increasing levels of instructional intensity based on
18 student need and demonstrated response to instruction.

19 D. It is further the intent of the Legislature that strong core
20 literacy instruction consists of explicit, systematic instruction in
21 foundational reading and writing skills including phonological
22 awareness, decoding, encoding, spelling, sentence-level writing,
23 language development, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension,
24

1 recognizing the reciprocal relationship between reading and writing
2 proficiency.

3 E. Each public school district in this state shall ensure that
4 all students receive a well-rounded education that is focused on
5 building deep foundations in reading, writing, and mathematics. The
6 State Board of Education shall encourage school districts to
7 integrate the teaching of the other curricular areas in the subject
8 matter standards adopted by the Board with the instruction of
9 reading, writing, and mathematics. All teachers of reading in the
10 public schools in this state in kindergarten through third grade
11 shall incorporate into instruction the five elements of reading
12 instruction which are phonological awareness, decoding, fluency,
13 vocabulary, and comprehension.

14 ~~D.~~ F. It is the intent of the Legislature that beginning with
15 the 2025-2026 school year, school districts and charter schools in
16 this state shall be prohibited from using the three-cueing system
17 model of teaching students to read. For the purposes of this
18 section, the "three-cueing system" means any model of teaching
19 students to read based on meaning, structure, syntax, and visual
20 cues, which may also be known as meaning, structure, and visual
21 (MSV), balanced literacy, or whole language.

22 SECTION 3. NEW LAW A new section of law to be codified
23 in the Oklahoma Statutes as Section 1210.508B-1 of Title 70, unless
24 there is created a duplication in numbering, reads as follows:

1 A. As used in the Strong Readers Act:

2 1. "Grade-level targets" means the grade-specific benchmark
3 scores established for the screening instrument selected by the
4 State Board of Education in coordination with the Commission for
5 Educational Quality and Accountability;

6 2. "Highly qualified teacher" means a teacher or provider with
7 appropriate training and demonstrated competency in evidence-based
8 reading intervention;

9 3. "Literacy coach" means an educator with demonstrated
10 expertise in evidence-based literacy instruction who provides job-
11 embedded professional learning, modeling, observation, and feedback
12 to teachers to strengthen core instruction and intervention
13 practices within a multi-tiered system of supports framework. The
14 primary responsibility of a literacy coach is to support educators
15 and administrators in improving instructional practices and
16 schoolwide literacy systems. A literacy coach shall not serve in a
17 supervisory or evaluative capacity to maintain a non-evaluative role
18 that fosters professional trust and growth;

19 4. "Multi-tiered system of supports" or "MTSS" means a
20 framework that provides strong core literacy instruction to all
21 students and increasingly intensive levels of instructional support
22 based on student need and demonstrated response to instruction;

23 5. "Reading deficiency" means performance below grade-level
24 targets on a screening or diagnostic assessment indicating that a

1 student is not meeting grade-level expectations in one or more
2 reading skill areas;

3 6. "Reading interventionist" means an educator trained in
4 evidence-based reading instruction who provides supplemental or
5 intensive intervention to students identified with a reading
6 deficiency or significant reading deficiency, aligned to student
7 data and delivered in addition to core instruction;

8 7. "Reading specialist" means an educator who has completed
9 advanced preparation in literacy instruction and assessment and is
10 responsible for designing, delivering, and monitoring targeted and
11 intensive reading intervention services, as well as supporting
12 teachers in addressing reading deficiencies across grade levels. A
13 reading specialist shall have completed a graduate-level specialist
14 degree in reading or literacy and passed the applicable
15 certification examination and shall hold a valid teaching
16 certificate with a reading specialist endorsement;

17 8. "Science of reading" means the body of scientifically based
18 research conducted over several decades and across multiple
19 countries, drawing from multiple disciplines including cognitive
20 psychology, linguistics, neuroscience, and education, that explains
21 how individuals learn to read and write. The science of reading
22 informs instructional practices that are explicit, systematic, and
23 cumulative, and are aligned to the development of phonological
24

1 awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, comprehension, written
2 expression, and oral language development;

3 9. "Significant reading deficiency" means a reading deficiency
4 that persists despite supplemental intervention and indicates a need
5 for intensive intervention based on student data and response to
6 instruction;

7 10. "Tier 1 - Core Instruction" or "Tier 1" means:

8 a. the evidence-based reading instruction provided to all
9 students as part of the general education program.

10 Tier 1 instruction shall include high-quality,
11 standards-aligned literacy instruction grounded in the
12 science of reading and delivered during the regular
13 instructional day,

14 b. Tier 1 shall include universal screening in
15 kindergarten through third grade and ongoing
16 assessment used to identify students who may require
17 additional instructional support. Tier 1 may also
18 include targeted instructional supports delivered
19 within the core instructional setting to address
20 emerging reading needs, and

21 c. Tier 1 instruction is intended to meet the needs of
22 the majority of students through strong classroom
23 instruction and prevention-focused supports;

24 11. "Tier 2 - Supplemental Intervention" or "Tier 2" means:

1 a. targeted reading intervention provided in addition to
2 Tier 1 core instruction for students identified
3 through screening and progress-monitoring data as
4 requiring additional instructional support to meet
5 grade-level reading expectations. Tier 2 intervention
6 shall:

7 (1) provide additional instructional time beyond Tier
8 1 core instruction,

9 (2) be delivered in small-group settings, typically
10 consisting of three to five students, using
11 evidence-based instructional practices aligned
12 with the science of reading,

13 (3) target specific skill deficits identified through
14 assessment data, and

15 (4) include regular progress monitoring to determine
16 the effectiveness of the intervention and guide
17 instructional adjustments, and

18 b. a student shall be designated as receiving Tier 2
19 supplemental intervention only when the student is
20 actively participating in scheduled intervention
21 services beyond Tier 1 instruction; and

22 12. "Tier 3 - Intensive Intervention" or "Tier 3" means:

23 a. individualized or highly targeted reading intervention
24 provided in addition to Tier 1 core instruction and

1 Tier 2 supplemental intervention for students
2 demonstrating a significant reading deficiency. Tier
3 3 intervention shall:

4 (1) provide substantially increased instructional
5 intensity and frequency beyond Tier 2 supports,

6 (2) be delivered in individualized or small group
7 settings, typically consisting of one to three
8 students,

9 (3) be guided by diagnostic assessment to address
10 specific reading skill deficits, and

11 (4) include frequent progress monitoring to evaluate
12 student response to intervention and guide
13 instructional decision-making, and

14 b. a student shall be designated as receiving Tier 3
15 intensive intervention only when the student is
16 actively participating in scheduled intensive
17 intervention services beyond Tier 1 instruction.

18 B. The State Board of Education shall promulgate rules
19 establishing implementation guidance for each tier defined in
20 paragraphs 10 through 12 of subsection A of this section including
21 expectations related to instructional time, group size,
22 documentation requirements, and progress-monitoring practices
23 necessary to ensure the effective delivery of intervention services.
24

SECTION 4. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508C,
as last amended by Section 2, Chapter 297, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S.
Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508C), is amended to read as follows:

Section 1210.508C. A. To identify students who have a reading
deficiency or characteristics of dyslexia that lead to or cause
reading difficulty, each student enrolled in kindergarten and first,
second, and third grade in a public school in this state shall be
screened at the beginning, middle, and end of each school year for
monitoring of progress and for measurement of reading skills
~~including, but not limited to, phonological awareness, decoding,~~
~~fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension. A screening instrument~~
~~approved by the State Board of Education, in consultation with the~~
~~Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability and the~~
~~Secretary of Education, shall.~~ The Office of Educational Quality
and Accountability shall evaluate and rank up to three screening
instruments, which shall be approved by the Commission for
Educational Quality and Accountability. The State Board of
Education shall select one screening instrument approved by the
Commission to be utilized for the purposes of this section.

The selected screening instrument shall meet the following
criteria:

1. Can assess for phonological awareness, sound-symbol
recognition, alphabet knowledge, rapid naming skills, decoding and

1 encoding skills, oral reading accuracy and fluency, vocabulary, and
2 comprehension, as developmentally appropriate;

3 2. Can document the validity and reliability of each
4 assessment;

5 3. Can identify students who are at risk for reading and math
6 deficiency and monitor student progress throughout the school year;

7 4. Can be linked to, and can accurately predict, performance on
8 the Oklahoma School Testing Program;

9 5. Is normed beyond elementary grades;

10 6. Can assess students with disabilities and English language
11 learners;

12 7. Is accompanied by a data management system that provides
13 profiles of each student, class, grade level, and school building.

14 The profiles shall identify the instructional point of need and
15 reading achievement level for each student;

16 8. Is capable of reporting student-level data to the State
17 Department of Education and the Office of Educational Quality and
18 Accountability; and

19 9. Cannot be completed autonomously by a student on an
20 electronic device.

21 B. In determining which screening instrument to approve and
22 utilize, the ~~State Board of Education, the~~ Commission for
23 Educational Quality and Accountability, and the ~~Secretary~~ State
24

1 Board of Education shall take into consideration at a minimum the
2 following factors:

3 1. The time required to conduct the screening instrument with
4 the intention of minimizing the impact on instructional time;

5 2. The timeliness in reporting screening instrument results to
6 teachers, administrators, and parents and legal guardians of
7 students; ~~and~~

8 3. The integration of the screening instrument into reading and
9 math curriculum.

10 ~~B. Beginning in the 2025-2026 school year, the State Board of~~
11 ~~Education shall approve no fewer than three screening instruments~~
12 ~~for use at the beginning, middle, and end of the school year for~~
13 ~~monitoring of progress and for measurement of reading skills as~~
14 ~~required in subsection A of this section. The screening instruments~~
15 ~~shall meet the following criteria:~~

16 1. ~~Assess for phonological awareness, decoding, fluency,~~
17 ~~vocabulary, and comprehension;~~

18 2. ~~Document the validity and reliability of each assessment;~~

19 3. ~~Can be used for identifying students who are at risk for~~
20 ~~reading deficiency and progress monitoring throughout the school~~
21 ~~year;~~

22 4. ~~Can be used to assess students with disabilities and English~~
23 ~~language learners; and~~

1 ~~5. Accompanied by a data management system that provides~~
2 ~~profiles of each student, class, grade level, and school building.~~
3 ~~The profiles shall identify each student's instructional point of~~
4 ~~need and reading achievement level. The State Board shall also~~
5 ~~determine other comparable reading assessments for diagnostic~~
6 ~~purposes to be used for students at risk of reading failure; and~~

7 4. The ability to report all reading screening results to both
8 the State Department of Education and the Office of Educational
9 Quality and Accountability.

10 C. 1. Exemptions to the screening requirements of this section
11 may be provided to students who have documented evidence that they
12 meet at least one of the following criteria as related to the
13 provision of classroom instruction:

- 14 a. the student participates in the Oklahoma Alternate
15 Assessment Program (OAAP) and is taught using
16 alternate methods,
- 17 b. the student's primary expressive or receptive
18 communication is sign language,
- 19 c. the student's primary form of written or read text is
20 Braille, or
- 21 d. the student's primary expressive or receptive language
22 is not English, the student is identified as an
23 English learner using a state-approved identification
24 assessment, and the student has had less than one (1)

1 school year of instruction in an English-learner
2 program.

3 2. A public school that grants an exemption pursuant to
4 paragraph 1 of this subsection shall provide ongoing evidence of
5 student progression toward English language acquisition with the
6 same frequency as administration of screening assessments. Evidence
7 may include, but not be limited to, student progression toward OAAP
8 reading essential elements, proficiency in sign language and reading
9 comprehension, and proficiency in Braille and reading comprehension.

10 D. 1. Students who are administered a screening instrument
11 pursuant to subsection A of this section and are found not to be
12 meeting grade-level targets shall be provided a program of reading
13 ~~instruction designed to enable students to acquire the appropriate~~
14 ~~grade-level reading skills. The program of reading instruction~~
15 ~~shall be based on scientific reading research and align with the~~
16 ~~subject matter standards adopted by the State Board of Education. A~~
17 ~~program of reading instruction shall include:~~

- 18 a. ~~sufficient additional in-school instructional time for~~
19 ~~the acquisition of phonological awareness, decoding,~~
20 ~~fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension,~~
21 b. ~~if necessary and if funding is available, tutorial~~
22 ~~instruction after regular school hours, on Saturdays,~~
23 ~~and during summer; however, such instruction may not~~
24 ~~be counted toward the one-hundred-eighty-day or one-~~

~~thousand eighty-hour school year required in Section 1-109 of this title,~~

- ~~e. assessments identified for diagnostic purposes and periodic monitoring to measure the acquisition of reading skills including, but not limited to, phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension, as identified in the student's program of reading instruction,~~
- ~~d. high-quality instructional materials grounded in scientifically based reading research, and~~
- ~~e. a means of providing every family of a student in prekindergarten, kindergarten, and first, second, and third grade access to free online evidence-based literacy instruction resources to support the student's literacy development at home. intervention services, as determined by their individual reading intervention plan. Such reading intervention services shall not occur during math instruction.~~

2. A student enrolled in kindergarten or first, second, or third grade who exhibits a ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency at any time based on the screening instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section and any fourth-grade student promoted for good cause pursuant to subsection L of this section shall receive an individual reading intervention plan no later than thirty

1 (30) days after the identification of the ~~deficiency in~~ reading
2 deficiency. The reading intervention plan shall be provided in
3 addition to ~~core~~ Tier 1 reading instruction that is provided to all
4 students. The reading intervention plan shall:

- 5 a. describe the ~~research-based~~ reading intervention
6 services the student will receive to remedy the
7 ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency,
- 8 b. provide explicit and systematic instruction in
9 phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary,
10 and comprehension, as applicable,
- 11 c. monitor the reading progress of each student's reading
12 skills throughout the school year and adjust
13 instruction according to the student's needs, and
- 14 d. continue until the student is determined to be meeting
15 grade-level targets in reading based on the screening
16 ~~instruments~~ instrument administered pursuant to
17 subsection A of this section or assessments identified
18 for diagnostic purposes and periodic monitoring
19 ~~pursuant to subparagraph c of paragraph 1 of this~~
20 ~~subsection~~ by the State Board of Education.

21 3. The reading intervention plan for each student identified
22 with a ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency shall be developed by a
23 Student Reading Proficiency Team and shall include supplemental
24

1 instructional services and supports. Each team shall be composed
2 of:

- 3 a. the parent or legal guardian of the student,
- 4 b. the teacher assigned to the student who had
5 responsibility for reading instruction in that
6 academic year,
- 7 c. a teacher who is responsible for reading instruction
8 and is assigned to teach in the next grade level of
9 the student, ~~and~~
- 10 d. a certified reading specialist or an individual with
11 advanced training or specialization in literacy
12 instruction, ~~if one is available and~~
- 13 e. the principal, vice principal, or designate.

14 4. ~~A school district shall notify the parent or legal guardian~~
15 ~~of any student in kindergarten or first, second, or third grade who~~
16 ~~exhibits a deficiency in reading at any time based on the screening~~
17 ~~instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section.~~
18 ~~The notification shall occur no later than thirty (30) days after~~
19 ~~the identification of the deficiency in reading. The State Board of~~
20 Education, in consultation with the Office of Educational Quality
21 and Accountability, shall annually define and set benchmarks for
22 screening instrument results that are predictive of future
23 performance on the state summative assessment to assist in
24 identifying intervention tiers within a reading intervention plan.

1 Annually, the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability shall
2 analyze and report to the State Department of Education the
3 correlation of screening instrument tiers to state summative tiers
4 using predictive modeling and prior year formative and summative
5 testing results.

6 5. Reading intervention shall not be provided solely by digital
7 technology. Reading intervention shall include a majority of direct
8 instruction from a teacher or reading specialist trained in the
9 science of reading.

10 E. 1. Every school district shall adopt and implement a
11 district strong readers plan which has had input from school
12 administrators, teachers, and parents and legal guardians, and ~~if~~
13 ~~possible~~ a reading specialist or interventionist, and which shall be
14 submitted electronically to and approved by the State Board of
15 Education. The plan shall be updated annually if changes have been
16 made to the plan. ~~School districts shall not be required to~~
17 ~~electronically submit the annual updates to the Board if the last~~
18 ~~plan submitted to the Board was approved and expenditures for the~~
19 ~~program include only expenses relating to individual and small group~~
20 ~~tutoring, purchase of and training in the use of screening and~~
21 ~~assessment measures, summer school programs, and Saturday school~~
22 ~~programs. If any expenditure for the program is deleted or changed~~
23 ~~or any other type of expenditure for the program is implemented, the~~
24 ~~school district shall be required to submit the latest annual update~~

1 ~~to the Board for approval.~~ The district strong readers plan shall
2 include a plan for each site which includes an analysis of the data
3 provided by the Oklahoma School Testing Program and other reading
4 assessments utilized as required in this section, and which outlines
5 how each school site will comply with the provisions of the Strong
6 Readers Act.

7 2. The State Board of Education shall adopt rules for the
8 implementation and evaluation of the provisions of the Strong
9 Readers Act. The evaluation shall include, but not be limited to,
10 an analysis of the data required in subsection ~~E~~ S of this section.

11 ~~F. 1. Any first-grade, second-grade, or third-grade student~~
12 ~~who demonstrates proficiency in reading through a grade-level~~
13 ~~appropriate screening instrument approved pursuant to subsection B~~
14 ~~of this section shall not require a program of reading instruction~~
15 ~~or an individual reading intervention plan. After a student has~~
16 ~~demonstrated proficiency through a screening instrument, the~~
17 ~~district shall provide notification to the parent or legal guardian~~
18 ~~of the student that he or she has satisfied the requirements of the~~
19 ~~Strong Readers Act. The district shall continue to monitor the~~
20 ~~student in the next successive grade level to ensure he or she~~
21 ~~maintains proficiency.~~

22 ~~2. Beginning with the 2025-2026 school year, if a third-grade~~
23 ~~student is identified at any point of the academic year as having a~~
24 ~~significant reading deficiency, which shall be defined as not~~

~~meeting grade-level targets on a screening instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section, the district shall provide the student with intensive intervention services for the appropriate amount of the instructional day consistent with the individual reading intervention plan developed pursuant to paragraph 2 of subsection D of this section and as determined by the Student Reading Proficiency Team. Intensive intervention services shall continue until the student demonstrates proficiency at his or her grade level based on a screening instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section.~~

~~G.~~ 1. Beginning with the 2027-2028 school year:

- a. if a first-grade student has demonstrated the need for reading intervention services and is not meeting grade-level targets by the end of the first grade, the district shall place the student in a stand-alone transitional second-grade classroom or promote the student to second grade while providing targeted transitional intervention instruction in pull-out sessions, and
- b. if a second-grade student has demonstrated the need for reading intervention services and is not meeting grade-level targets by the end of the second grade, the district shall place the student in a stand-alone transitional third-grade classroom or promote the

1 student to third grade while providing targeted
2 transitional intervention instruction in pull-out
3 sessions.

4 2. If a student is subject to the provisions of paragraph 1 of
5 this subsection, the family of the student shall be provided with
6 the option for the student to attend a summer tutoring program or a
7 summer reading academy. The State Department of Education shall
8 also approve one or two online or workbook-based summer tutoring
9 programs for use by students under this paragraph. School districts
10 shall also provide the parents or legal guardians of the student
11 with a list of summer literacy programs available if a summer
12 academy, as described in Section 1210.508E of this title, is not
13 offered by the school district.

14 G. Each school district shall annually report in an electronic
15 format to the State Department of Education, the Office of
16 Educational Quality and Accountability, and the Secretary of
17 Education the number of students in kindergarten through third grade
18 per grade level who exhibit grade-level reading proficiency, the
19 number of students per grade level who received ~~intensive~~ reading
20 ~~intervention services pursuant to paragraph 2 of subsection F~~ D of
21 this section, the number of students per grade level who attended a
22 summer academy as provided for in Section 1210.508E of this title,
23 the number of students per grade level who exhibited improved
24 reading proficiency after completion of ~~intensive~~ reading

1 intervention services, and the number of students per grade level
2 who are still in need of ~~intensive~~ reading intervention services.
3 The State Department of Education shall publicly report the
4 aggregate and district-specific numbers submitted pursuant to this
5 subsection on its website and shall provide electronic copies of the
6 report to the Governor, Secretary of Education, President Pro
7 Tempore of the Senate, Speaker of the House of Representatives, and
8 to the respective chairs of the committees with responsibility for
9 common education policy in each legislative chamber.

10 H. The parent or legal guardian of any student who is found to
11 have a reading deficiency ~~and is not meeting grade-level reading~~
12 ~~targets~~ and has been provided a program of reading ~~instruction~~
13 intervention services as provided for in paragraph 1 of subsection D
14 of this section shall be notified in writing ~~of~~ no later than thirty
15 (30) days after the identification of the reading deficiency. The
16 notification shall be accompanied by the individual reading
17 intervention plan developed in paragraph 2 of subsection D of this
18 section. The notification shall include the following:

19 1. That the student has been identified as having a ~~substantial~~
20 ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency;

21 2. A description of the current services that are provided to
22 the student pursuant to subsection D of this section;

23 3. A description of the proposed ~~intensive~~ reading intervention
24 services and supports that will be provided to the student that are

1 designed to remediate the identified area of reading deficiency as
2 provided for in ~~paragraph 2~~ of subsection ~~F~~ D of this section;

3 4. That the parent or legal guardian shall be informed in
4 writing of the progress of the student toward grade-level reading at
5 least every thirty (30) days and provided with strategies to assist
6 at home;

7 5. That if the child's reading deficiency is not remediated by
8 the end of third grade, the child shall not be promoted to fourth
9 grade unless a good-cause exemption is met;

10 6. That a student who is promoted to the fourth grade for good
11 cause shall receive ~~supplemental intensive~~ reading intervention
12 services unless he or she is a student who meets the definition of a
13 student with the most significant cognitive disabilities;

14 ~~5.—Strategies~~ 7. A description of the specific skill deficits
15 of the child and strategies for parents or legal guardians to use in
16 helping their child succeed in reading proficiency; and

17 ~~6.~~ 8. The grade-level performance scores of the student; and

18 9. That while the statewide English Language Arts assessment is
19 the initial determinate for promotion, students may be provided with
20 an alternative reading assessment option that is recommended by the
21 Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability and approved
22 by the State Department of Education to demonstrate sufficient
23 reading skills for promotion to fourth grade.
24

1 I. No student may be assigned to a grade level based solely on
2 age or other factors that constitute social promotion.

3 J. 1. Any incoming third-grade student identified with a
4 reading deficiency shall be provided reading intervention services
5 to remedy his or her specific reading deficiency. Intervention
6 services shall include effective instructional strategies to
7 accelerate student progress and be delivered by a highly qualified
8 teacher.

9 2. Public school districts shall review individual reading
10 intervention plans for all incoming third-grade students identified
11 with a reading deficiency. The review shall address additional
12 supports and services the student will receive. The supports and
13 services shall include reading instruction and reading intervention
14 services and supports to correct any identified area of reading
15 deficiency.

16 K. 1. Beginning with the 2027-2028 school year, third-grade
17 students shall demonstrate sufficient reading skills for promotion
18 to fourth grade. Students shall be provided the following options
19 to demonstrate sufficient reading skills for promotion to fourth
20 grade:

- 21 a. scoring above the below basic level on the third-grade
22 statewide English Language Arts assessment, or
23 b. earning an acceptable score on an alternative
24 standardized reading assessment as recommended by the

Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability
and approved by the State Board of Education.

2. If the third-grade student cannot demonstrate sufficient
reading skills on one of the two options described in paragraph 1 of
this subsection and does not qualify for a good-cause exemption, the
student shall be retained in the third grade for the next school
year. Screening instruments described in this section shall not be
used for promotion purposes.

L. The school district board of education may only exempt
students from mandatory third-grade retention, as provided in
subsection K of this section, for good cause. A student who is
promoted to fourth grade with a good-cause exemption, except for
students who meet the definition of a student with the most
significant cognitive disabilities, shall continue to receive
reading intervention services that includes specific reading
strategies prescribed in the student's individual reading
intervention plan until the deficiency is remedied. The school
district shall assist schools and teachers with the implementation
of reading strategies that research has shown to be successful in
improving reading among students with reading difficulties. Good-
cause exemptions shall be limited to the following:

1. Students identified as English language learners who have
had less than two (2) consecutive years of instruction in an
English-learner program;

1 2. Students with disabilities who participate in the statewide
2 English Language Arts assessment and who have an individualized
3 education program (IEP) that reflects that the student has received
4 intensive reading intervention for more than two (2) years but still
5 demonstrates a reading deficiency, or who was previously retained
6 for one (1) year in kindergarten, first, second, or third grade; and

7 3. Students who have received reading intervention services for
8 two (2) or more years but still demonstrate a reading deficiency,
9 and who were previously retained in kindergarten, first, second, or
10 third grade for a total of two (2) years. No student shall be
11 retained twice in third grade.

12 M. Requests to exempt students from the mandatory third-grade
13 retention requirement, as provided in subsection K of this section,
14 using one of the good-cause exemptions, as described in subsection L
15 of this section, shall be made consistent with the following:

16 1. Documentation shall be submitted from the student's teacher
17 to the school principal indicating that the promotion of the student
18 is appropriate. Such documentation shall consist only of the good-
19 cause exemption being requested and the existing reading
20 intervention plan or IEP;

21 2. The school principal shall review and discuss the
22 recommendation for exemption with the student's teacher. If the
23 principal determines that the student meets one of the good-cause
24 exemptions based on the discussion and documentation provided, the

1 school principal shall make such recommendation in writing to the
2 school district superintendent. The school district superintendent
3 shall accept or reject the school principal's recommendation in
4 writing; and

5 3. The parents or legal guardians of a third-grade student
6 eligible for a good-cause exemption may choose that the student be
7 retained for one (1) year even if the school district superintendent
8 accepts a recommendation for a good-cause exemption pursuant to this
9 subsection.

10 N. The school district shall provide written notification to
11 the parent or legal guardian of any student who is retained. Such
12 notification shall state that his or her child has not met the
13 reading level required for promotion to the fourth grade, the
14 reasons the child is not eligible for a good-cause exemption, and
15 that his or her child will be retained in third grade. The
16 notification shall include a description of the proposed reading
17 intervention services that will be provided to the child to remedy
18 the identified areas of reading deficiency in the retained year.

19 O. 1. Students that are withdrawn from public school to bypass
20 third-grade retention requirements, as outlined in subsection K of
21 this section, shall be subject to screening upon return to the
22 public school system to determine appropriate grade level upon re-
23 entry.

1 2. If a third-grade student subject to retention as provided
2 for in subsection K of this section transfers to a public school
3 district, a charter school, or a virtual charter school, the
4 requirements to retain the student in third grade shall not be
5 altered by the receiving school.

6 P. Beginning with the 2027-2028 school year, students retained
7 under the provisions of subsection K of this section shall be
8 provided reading intervention services to remedy the student's
9 specific reading deficiency. The reading intervention services
10 shall include effective instructional strategies to accelerate
11 student progress. Each school district shall conduct a review of
12 student reading intervention plans for all students retained in
13 third grade. The review shall address additional supports and
14 services needed to remedy the identified areas of reading deficiency
15 and ensure the following are provided to retained students:

16 1. A teacher with appropriate training and demonstrated
17 competency in evidence-based reading intervention. School districts
18 with only one third-grade teacher are exempt from the requirements
19 of this paragraph;

20 2. Reading intervention services and supports to correct the
21 identified areas of reading deficiency;

22 3. One of the following intervention supports:

23 a. a transitional instructional setting designed to
24 produce learning gains sufficient to meet fourth-grade

1 performance standards in all other core academic areas
2 while continuing to correct the areas of reading
3 deficiency,

4 b. before- or after-school supplemental research-based
5 reading intervention delivered by a teacher or tutor
6 with specialized reading training, or

7 c. summer academy programs designed to ensure that
8 participating students successfully complete grade-
9 level competencies in reading to enhance next-grade
10 readiness; and

11 4. A "Read at Home" plan as created by the Office of
12 Educational Quality and Accountability shall be outlined in a
13 parental or legal guardian notification, including participation in
14 parent or legal guardian training workshops or regular parent-guided
15 or legal guardian-guided home reading activities which are aligned
16 to scientifically based reading research.

17 Q. 1. Each school district board of education shall annually
18 publish on the school website and report electronically to the State
19 Department of Education, the Office of Educational Quality and
20 Accountability, and the Secretary of Education by September 1 of
21 each year the following information on the prior school year:

22 a. the policies and procedures adopted by the school
23 district board of education to implement the
24 provisions of this section. The information submitted

1 shall include expenditures related to implementing the
2 provisions of this section, the number of staff
3 implementing the provisions of this section, and
4 average daily classroom time devoted to implementing
5 the provisions of this section,

6 b. by grade, the number and percentage of all students in
7 kindergarten through third grade who ~~did not meet~~
8 ~~grade-level targets~~ demonstrated a reading deficiency
9 based on a screening instrument administered pursuant
10 to subsection A of this section,

11 c. by grade, the number and percentage of all students in
12 kindergarten through third grade who have been
13 enrolled in the district for fewer than two (2) years,

14 d. by grade, the number and percentage of all students in
15 kindergarten through third grade who were retained,

16 e. by grade, the number and percentage of students in
17 kindergarten through third grade who demonstrated
18 grade-level proficiency based on a screening
19 instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of
20 this section, ~~and~~

21 ~~e.~~

22 f. by grade, the number and percentage of students in
23 kindergarten through third grade who are on an
24 individualized education program (IEP) in accordance

1 with the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act
2 (IDEA) and who demonstrated grade-level proficiency
3 based on a screening instrument administered pursuant
4 to subsection A of this section or an alternative
5 assessment prescribed by the student's IEP,

6 g. the number and percentage of all students in third
7 grade who demonstrated sufficient reading skills for
8 promotion to the next grade on the alternative reading
9 assessment,

10 h. the number and percentage of students in third grade
11 who were promoted to fourth grade for good cause and
12 the applicable good-cause exemption specified in
13 subsection L of this section, and

14 i. the performance of fourth-grade students on the
15 statewide English Language Arts assessment who were
16 promoted with a good-cause exemption in the previous
17 school year.

18 2. The State Department of Education shall establish a uniform
19 format for school districts to report the information required in
20 this subsection. The format shall be developed with input from
21 school districts and shall be provided not later than ninety (90)
22 days prior to the annual due date. The Department shall annually
23 compile the information required, along with state-level summary
24 information, and electronically report the information to the

1 public, the Governor, the Secretary of Education, the President Pro
2 Tempore of the Senate, and the Speaker of the House of
3 Representatives and shall post such information on its website.

4 ~~K.~~ R. The State Department of Education shall provide technical
5 assistance as needed to aid school districts in administering the
6 provisions of the Strong Readers Act.

7 ~~L.~~ S. On or before January 31 of each year, the State
8 Department of Education shall electronically submit to the Governor,
9 the President Pro Tempore of the Senate, the Speaker of the House of
10 Representatives, and members of the committees with responsibility
11 over common education in both houses of the Legislature a Strong
12 Readers Report which shall include, but is not limited to, trend
13 data detailing three (3) years of data, disaggregated by student
14 subgroups to include economically disadvantaged, major racial or
15 ethnic groups, students with disabilities, and English language
16 learners, as appropriate for the following:

17 1. The statewide aggregate number and percentage of students in
18 kindergarten through third grade determined to be at risk for
19 reading difficulties compared to the total number of students
20 enrolled in each grade;

21 2. The statewide aggregate number and percentage of students in
22 kindergarten who continue to be at risk for reading difficulties as
23 determined by the year-end administration of the screening
24 instrument required in subsection A of this section;

1 3. The statewide aggregate number and percentage of students in
2 kindergarten through third grade who have successfully completed
3 their program of reading instruction and are reading on grade level
4 as determined by the results of a screening ~~instruments~~ instrument
5 administered pursuant to subsection A of this section;

6 4. The statewide aggregate and district-specific number and
7 percentage of students that meet or do not meet grade-level targets
8 for reading based on a screening ~~instruments~~ instrument administered
9 pursuant to subsection A of this section;

10 5. The statewide aggregate and district-specific number and
11 percentage of students that were retained in third grade;

12 6. The amount of funds received by each district for
13 implementation of the Strong Readers Act;

14 ~~6.~~ 7. An evaluation and narrative interpretation of the report
15 data analyzing the impact of the Strong Readers Act on students'
16 ability to read at grade level;

17 ~~7.~~ 8. The type of reading instruction practices and methods
18 currently being used by school districts in the state;

19 ~~8.~~ 9. Socioeconomic information, access to reading resources
20 outside of school, and screening for and identification of learning
21 disabilities for students not reading at the appropriate grade level
22 in kindergarten and first through third grade;

23 ~~9.~~ 10. By grade level, the types of intensive intervention
24 efforts being conducted by school districts for students who are not

1 on an IEP and who are not reading at the appropriate grade level and
2 for students who are on an IEP and who are not reading at the
3 appropriate grade level; and

4 ~~10.~~ 11. Any recommendations for improvements or amendments to
5 the Strong Readers Act.

6 The State Department of Education may contract with an
7 independent entity for the reporting and analysis requirements of
8 this subsection.

9 ~~M.~~ T. Copies of the results of the screening ~~instruments~~
10 instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section
11 shall be made a part of the permanent record of each student.

12 SECTION 5. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508D,
13 as amended by Section 6, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
14 2025, Section 1210.508D), is amended to read as follows:

15 Section 1210.508D. A. Contingent on the provision of
16 appropriated funds designated for the Strong Readers Act, ~~school~~
17 ~~districts may be allocated monies for each enrolled kindergarten~~
18 ~~student or first, second, and third grade student of the current~~
19 ~~school year who is found to be in need of remediation or intensive~~
20 ~~intervention services in reading. The allocation shall be~~
21 ~~distributed to each school district upon approval of the strong~~
22 ~~readers plan for the school district by the State Board of Education~~
23 ~~and the submittal of a child-count report to the State Department of~~
24 ~~Education that details the number of students identified as needing~~

~~remediation or intensive intervention services in reading. To determine a per student allocation amount, the total amount of funds available for allocation each year shall be divided by the total number of students in the state identified as in need of remediation or intensive intervention services in reading as provided for in Section 1210.508C of this title. Each school district shall be allocated an amount equal to the per student allocation amount multiplied by the number of identified students enrolled in the school district.~~

~~B. Beginning with the 2022-2023 school year, districts receiving more than Two Thousand Five Hundred Dollars (\$2,500.00) pursuant to subsection A of this section shall spend no less than ten percent (10%) to provide professional development for teachers teaching prekindergarten through grade five. The professional development shall include training in the science of reading including how students learn to read; training in providing explicit and systematic instruction in phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension; implementing reading strategies that research has shown to be successful in improving reading among students with reading difficulties; and instructional materials required for implementation.~~

~~C. By June 30, 2022, the Department shall approve and publish a list of professional development programs that are evidence-based and directly address the cognitive science of how students learn to~~

~~read for which districts are permitted to use the funds received~~
~~under this section.~~ each school district shall receive a base
literacy allocation calculated on a per-student basis for each
student enrolled in kindergarten and grades one through three, as
reported in the October 1 enrollment counts of the current school
year.

The base literacy allocation shall support the prevention of
reading deficiencies and the implementation of strong core literacy
instruction within Tier 1 of a multi-tiered system of supports
(MTSS) framework, including, but not limited to:

1. Evidence-based core literacy instruction and instructional
materials aligned with the science of reading;

2. Universal screening and diagnostic assessment necessary to
identify students at risk for reading deficiencies;

3. Progress monitoring and data use to inform instructional
decisions;

4. Family literacy resources and engagement activities aligned
with classroom instruction; and

5. Professional development and instructional coaching
necessary to implement the district strong readers plan.

The State Board of Education shall allocate not less than forty
percent (40%) of funds appropriated for purposes of this section to
support the base literacy allocation described in this subsection.

1 B. 1. In addition to the base literacy allocation provided
2 pursuant to subsection A of this section, school districts shall
3 receive supplemental weighted funding for students identified
4 through screening and progress-monitoring data as requiring
5 additional reading intervention services within a multi-tiered
6 system of supports (MTSS) framework.

7 2. Supplemental weighted funding shall support intervention
8 services beyond Tier 1 core instruction and shall be distributed
9 according to the following categories:

10 a. Tier 2 - Supplemental Intervention Weight: Students
11 identified as requiring targeted reading intervention
12 beyond core instruction shall generate supplemental
13 funding to support additional instructional time,
14 reduced group size, and evidence-based intervention,
15 and

16 b. Tier 3 - Intensive Intervention Weight: Students
17 identified as demonstrating a significant reading
18 deficiency requiring intensive, individualized, or
19 highly targeted intervention shall generate
20 supplemental funding reflecting the increased
21 instructional intensity required at this level.

22 3. Supplemental funding received pursuant to this subsection
23 shall be used exclusively for intervention services beyond Tier 1
24 core instruction, including:

- a. additional instructional time devoted to reading intervention,
- b. reduced instructional group sizes necessary to deliver intensive instruction,
- c. specialized instructional materials and intervention programs aligned with the science of reading,
- d. compensation for educators delivering intervention services, and
- e. professional development necessary to ensure educators providing intervention services have extensive training in the science of reading.

4. The State Board of Education shall allocate not less than thirty percent (30%) of funds appropriated for purposes of this section to support supplemental weighted intervention funding described in this subsection and shall promulgate rules establishing the methodology for calculating weights, documentation requirements, and procedures for verifying intervention participation.

5. Students shall be counted for purposes of supplemental weighted funding pursuant to this subsection only when the school district has documented that the student is receiving intervention services consistent with the level of instructional intensity required at the applicable tier.

6. School districts shall maintain documentation demonstrating:

- a. identification of the student through an approved universal screening assessment and supporting diagnostic or progress-monitoring data,
- b. implementation of an intervention plan specifying the instructional approach, frequency, duration, and group size of intervention services, and
- c. ongoing progress monitoring used to determine the effectiveness of the intervention and inform instructional adjustments.

7. Students shall not generate supplemental weighted funding unless intervention services are provided beyond Tier 1 core instruction. The State Department of Education may review intervention documentation and program implementation to verify eligibility for supplemental weighted funding distributed pursuant to this section.

8. The State Board of Education shall promulgate rules establishing reasonable expectations for the proportion of students receiving supplemental and intensive intervention services within a multi-tiered system of supports framework.

9. When the reported percentage of students receiving Tier 2 or Tier 3 intervention services significantly exceeds expected ranges, the State Department of Education may require additional documentation or provide technical assistance to ensure intervention

1 services are implemented with the instructional intensity required
2 at each tier.

3 C. 1. In order to encourage continuous improvement in student
4 reading outcomes and to support the sustainability of effective
5 intervention services, a portion of funds appropriated pursuant to
6 this section shall be used to provide incentives to school districts
7 demonstrating measurable improvement in student reading performance.

8 2. Incentive funding may include recognition of:

9 a. students who demonstrate sufficient progress to exit
10 Tier 3 intensive intervention,

11 b. students who demonstrate sufficient progress to exit
12 Tier 2 supplemental intervention, and

13 c. schools or districts demonstrating measurable
14 reductions in the number or percentage of students
15 requiring supplemental or intensive intervention.

16 3. The State Board of Education shall allocate up to thirty
17 percent (30%) of funds appropriated for purposes of this section for
18 literacy improvement incentives and shall promulgate rules
19 establishing criteria for determining eligibility for such
20 incentives.

21 ~~D. If a teacher attends and completes a professional~~
22 ~~development institute in elementary reading approved by the~~
23 ~~Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability during the~~
24 ~~summer or when school is not in session, the teacher may receive a~~

~~stipend equal to the amount of the cost for a substitute teacher,~~
~~based on the amount of funds allocated.~~

SECTION 6. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508E,
as amended by Section 7, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
2025, Section 1210.508E), is amended to read as follows:

Section 1210.508E. A. If a teacher determines that a student
in kindergarten or first through third grade is not reading at grade
level by the end of the second quarter of the school year, the
parent or legal guardian of the student shall be notified of:

1. The reading level of the student;

2. The program of reading instruction for the student as
required pursuant to the Strong Readers Act; and

3. The potential need for the student to participate in a
summer academy or other program designed to assist the student in
attaining grade-level reading skills.

B. A teacher who determines a student in kindergarten or first
through third grade is not meeting grade-level targets for reading
may, after consultation with the parent or legal guardian of the
student, recommend that the student participate in and complete a
transitional instructional setting, before-, during-, or after-
school supplemental tutoring, a summer academy program, or other
program.

C. Summer academy programs shall be designed to ensure that
participating students successfully complete grade-level

1 competencies in reading to enhance next-grade readiness. A summer
2 academy reading program shall be a program that incorporates ~~the~~
3 ~~content of a scientifically research-based professional development~~
4 ~~program administered by the Commission for Educational Quality and~~
5 ~~Accountability or a scientifically research-based reading program~~
6 ~~administered by the State Board of Education~~ reading intervention
7 services and is taught by ~~teachers who have successfully completed~~
8 ~~professional development in the reading program~~ a highly qualified
9 teacher or ~~who are~~ a certified ~~as~~ reading ~~specialists~~ specialist.
10 The program shall provide explicit, systematic, sequential, and
11 cumulative reading intervention services and supports to correct
12 students' identified areas of reading deficiency.

13 D. School districts may approve an option for students who are
14 unable to attend a summer academy. The optional program may
15 include, but is not limited to, an approved private provider of
16 instruction, approved computer- or Internet-based instruction, or an
17 approved program of reading instruction monitored by the parent or
18 legal guardian. School districts shall not be required to pay for
19 the optional program but shall clearly communicate to the parent or
20 legal guardian the expectations of the program and any costs that
21 may be involved.

22 E. ~~Subject to the availability of funds, beginning 1.~~ School
23 districts shall provide at least one of the following reading
24 intervention options to all third-grade students scoring at the

1 below basic achievement level on the third-grade statewide English
2 Language Arts assessment, as well as students who have completed
3 kindergarten through second grade and are at risk of reading
4 deficiency as determined by a screening instrument administered
5 pursuant to subsection A of Section 1210.508C of this title:

- 6 a. before-, during-, or after-school supplemental
7 research-based reading intervention delivered by a
8 teacher or tutor with specialized reading training, or
9 b. summer academy programs designed to ensure that
10 participating students successfully complete grade-
11 level competencies in reading to enhance next-grade
12 readiness.

13 2. Summer reading academies shall include, at a minimum,
14 seventy (70) hours of instructional time in reading and shall not
15 use balanced literacy and whole language models, such as three-
16 cueing as defined in subsection F of Section 1210.508B of this
17 title.

18 F. Beginning one (1) year after implementation of this section,
19 the requirements of subsection ~~B~~ E of this section ~~may~~ shall be
20 expanded to apply to students in fourth grade. Each year
21 thereafter, the requirements ~~may~~ shall be expanded by one grade
22 level until the requirements apply to third-grade students through
23 eighth-grade students. ~~Summer academy programs~~ The reading
24 intervention options outlined in subsection E of this section shall

1 be designed for each grade level. Nothing in this section shall
2 prevent the State Board of Education or a school district board of
3 education from utilizing private, local, or federal funds to
4 implement this section.

5 ~~F. G.~~ The State Board of Education shall adopt rules to
6 implement the provisions of this section ~~which shall include~~
7 ~~requirements for instructional time for summer academy programs,~~
8 ~~teacher qualifications, and evaluation of student achievement as a~~
9 ~~result of summer academy programs or other optional programs~~ and
10 shall require school districts to report on the availability of
11 reading intervention options, the number of students participating
12 in each option, and evaluation of student achievement as a result of
13 each provided option.

14 SECTION 7. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508F,
15 as last amended by Section 3, Chapter 297, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S.
16 Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508F), is amended to read as follows:

17 Section 1210.508F. A. The Commission for Educational Quality
18 and Accountability shall ensure that the reading competencies for
19 elementary teachers are included in the competencies for special
20 education teachers.

21 B. The Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability in
22 collaboration with the Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education
23 shall ensure that all teachers ~~and adjuncts~~ of early childhood
24 education, elementary education, and special education are provided

1 quality training in intervention, instruction, and remediation
2 strategies in the science of reading to provide explicit and
3 systematic instruction in phonological awareness, decoding, fluency,
4 vocabulary, and comprehension and implement reading strategies that
5 research has shown to be successful in improving reading among
6 students with reading difficulties. Professional development may
7 include effective use of data, progress monitoring, and intervention
8 planning as it fits into a multi-tiered system of supports (MTSS)
9 framework. In addition, quality education for prospective teachers
10 shall be provided in research-based instructional strategies for
11 instruction, assessment, and intervention for literacy development
12 for all students including advanced readers, typically developing
13 readers, and struggling readers who are coping with a range of
14 challenges including, but not limited to, English language learners,
15 students at risk for reading deficiencies, and ~~learners~~ students
16 with handicapping conditions and learning disabilities, including
17 dyslexia. Quality training shall include guidance from professional
18 resources such as the Report of the National Reading Panel, Response
19 to Intervention guidelines, and professional organizations such as
20 the Council for Exceptional Children, International Dyslexia
21 Association, International Literacy Association, National Council of
22 Teachers of English, and National Association for the Education of
23 Young Children.

1 C. All institutions within The Oklahoma State System of Higher
2 Education that offer elementary, early childhood education, or
3 special education programs approved by the Commission for
4 Educational Quality and Accountability shall incorporate into those
5 programs the requirement that teacher candidates study the five
6 elements of reading instruction which are phonological awareness,
7 decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension and study methods
8 based on the science of reading. Teacher candidates shall study
9 strategies including, but not limited to, instruction that is
10 explicitly taught, sequenced, multimodal (reading, writing,
11 speaking, listening, hands-on, etc.), multidisciplinary, and
12 reflective to adapt for individual learners. Additionally, teacher
13 candidates shall study the negative impacts of balanced literacy and
14 whole language models, including three-cueing practices. They shall
15 further study how to identify balanced literacy and whole language
16 models including three-cueing practices in curriculum, and
17 subsequently, learn how to implement reading instruction using high-
18 quality instructional materials grounded in the science of reading
19 which do not include balanced literacy and whole language models
20 such as three-cueing, and the negative impacts of three-cueing.

21 D. Each teacher education program approved by the Commission
22 for Educational Quality and Accountability shall be audited by the
23 Commission to ensure teacher candidates are receiving quality
24 training in the science of reading. The Commission shall place the

1 accreditation of any noncompliant teacher education program on
2 probationary status and provide guidance for exiting probationary
3 status.

4 E. Effective July 1, 2025, any person seeking initial
5 certification in a special education, early childhood education, or
6 elementary education program in this state shall be required to
7 successfully complete a comprehensive reading instruction assessment
8 approved by the Commission for Educational Quality and
9 Accountability as a condition for certification. The assessment
10 shall be aligned to scientifically based reading research and
11 evaluate the certification applicant's knowledge and understanding
12 of the five elements of reading instruction which are phonological
13 awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension.

14 ~~E.~~ F. Candidates applying for adjunct positions, an alternative
15 placement teaching certificate, or an emergency teaching certificate
16 in elementary education shall complete instruction in the science of
17 reading as determined by the Commission for Educational Quality and
18 Accountability and the State Board of Education.

19 SECTION 8. AMENDATORY Section 2, Chapter 288, O.S.L.
20 2023, as amended by Section 9, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S.
21 Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508H), is amended to read as follows:

22 Section 1210.508H. A. Beginning with the ~~2023-2024~~ 2026-2027
23 school year, the State Department of Education shall establish and
24 maintain a ~~three-year pilot~~ program to employ a literacy

1 ~~instructional team~~ coaches to support school districts in
2 implementation of the requirements of Section 1210.508C of this
3 title. The Department shall provide technical assistance for
4 literacy instruction, dyslexia, and related disorders, and serve as
5 a primary source of information and support for schools,
6 administrators, and teachers in addressing the needs of students
7 struggling with literacy, reading deficiencies, or dyslexia, ~~and~~
8 ~~related disorders~~ or identified with the risk characteristics
9 associated with dyslexia.

10 B. The Department shall employ ~~a literacy instructional team~~
11 ~~with team members~~ coaches who are placed ~~regionally~~ in six major
12 geographic regions across the state. The literacy ~~instructional~~
13 ~~teams~~ coaches shall assist schools, administrators, educators, and
14 general education and special education teachers in recognizing
15 educational needs to improve literacy outcomes for all students
16 including those with reading deficiencies or dyslexia or identified
17 with the risk characteristics associated with dyslexia. Priority
18 shall be given to the lowest performing schools on the end-of-year
19 English Language Arts assessment or the statewide reading screener
20 as approved by the State Department of Education. The role of the
21 literacy ~~instructional team~~ coaches shall also include increasing
22 professional awareness and instructional competencies to meet the
23 educational needs of all students including those with reading
24 deficiencies or dyslexia or identified with risk characteristics

1 associated with dyslexia. The Department shall prioritize supports
2 and interventions including enrollment in reading trainings and
3 professional development for schools which have the highest
4 percentage of students who do not demonstrate sufficient reading
5 skills as established by the State Board of Education.

6 C. Literacy coaches shall provide systems and instructional
7 support to schools to strengthen the implementation of evidence-
8 based literacy instruction and intervention and to build the
9 capacity of educators and school leaders to sustain effective
10 literacy practices. Literacy coaches shall serve in a supportive,
11 non-evaluative capacity and shall not conduct personnel evaluations
12 or impose personnel actions.

13 D. Literacy ~~instructional team members~~ coaches employed by the
14 Department shall be required to pass Oklahoma's Foundations of
15 Reading test and shall have training in:

16 1. The science of how students learn to read including
17 phonological awareness, phonics, fluency, vocabulary, comprehension,
18 writing, and language;

19 2. Foundation of multisensory, explicit, systematic, and
20 structured reading instruction;

21 3. Identification of and the use of appropriate interventions,
22 accommodations, assistive technology, and teaching techniques for
23 ~~struggling~~ students with dysgraphia, dyslexia, a related reading
24 disorder, or reading deficiency;

1 4. The requirements of the Strong Readers Act;

2 5. Special education laws and procedures; and

3 6. Appropriate interventions, accommodations, and assistive
4 technology supports for students with dyslexia or a related
5 disorder.

6 ~~D.~~ E. The literacy ~~instructional team members~~ coaches employed
7 by the Department shall report to the Program Director for Literacy
8 at the Department and ~~have:~~

9 ~~1. A~~ shall consist of a minimum of five twenty regional
10 literacy ~~leads~~ coaches, at least one who shall be designated by the
11 Department as a dyslexia specialist to provide school districts with
12 support and resources that are necessary to assist students with
13 dyslexia. The Department shall give preference to educators
14 applying for regional literacy ~~lead~~ coaches who:

- 15 1. a. hold a master's degree in education with three (3)
16 years of documented successful experience teaching
17 reading as evidenced by reading assessment scores, or
18 b. hold a bachelor's degree with five (5) years of
19 documented successful experience teaching reading as
20 evidenced by reading assessment scores with a minimum
21 of three (3) years of literacy experience at the
22 state, district, or school level;

23 2. Have a valid certificate to teach issued by the State Board
24 of Education;

1 3. Have experience delivering professional development specific
2 to literacy instruction, mentoring and coaching classroom teachers,
3 leading others in a collaborative process, and analyzing and using
4 student performance data for instructional purposes;

5 ~~have~~ 4. Have an endorsement or certification as a certified
6 structured literacy dyslexia specialist or certified academic
7 language therapist~~;~~;

8 ~~b.~~ are

9 5. Are knowledgeable of multitiered systems of support~~;~~; and

10 ~~c.~~ have

11 6. Have been trained in the identification of and ~~intervention~~
12 ~~for dyslexia and related disorders including best practice~~ the use
13 of appropriate interventions and treatment models for,
14 accommodations, and teaching techniques for students with
15 dysgraphia, dyslexia; ~~and~~

16 ~~2. A minimum of ten literacy specialists,~~ a related reading
17 disorder, or reading deficiency.

18 F. 1. The State Department of Education shall assign literacy
19 coaches to school districts that are identified by the Department
20 based on the number and percentage of students scoring in the below
21 basic performance level on the statewide third-grade assessment
22 administered pursuant to Section 1210.508C of this title or the
23 statewide reading screener in kindergarten through second grade.

1 2. If a district already employs instructional coaches, that
2 district shall not be required to utilize Department-assigned
3 literacy coaches so long as the local instructional coaches
4 participate in a Department-led coaching improvement community
5 aligned to the science of reading and national coaching best
6 practices.

7 G. Literacy coaches assigned to school districts pursuant to
8 the provisions of this section shall:

9 1. Provide technical support to teachers responsible for
10 reading instruction and reading specialists;

11 2. Assist administrators, educators, and reading specialists in
12 implementing evidence-based literacy practices;

13 3. Design and conduct professional development to meet the
14 needs of teachers and administrators in the area of literacy;

15 4. Provide clear, practical, timely, and candid written and
16 oral feedback to teachers and administrators based on coaching
17 cycles; and

18 5. Meet regularly with teachers, reading specialists, and
19 administrators to review literacy data and make recommendations for
20 adjustments in instructional practices.

21 H. The Department shall give preference to educators applying
22 for literacy specialist to become a literacy coach who:

23 ~~a.~~ have

24 1. Have training in the science of reading7;

b. are

2. Are knowledgeable of ~~multitiered~~ multi-tiered systems of support, and;

e. have

3. Have been trained in the identification of and ~~intervention~~ for dyslexia and related disorders including best practice the use of appropriate interventions and treatment models for, accommodations, and teaching techniques for students with dysgraphia, dyslexia, a related reading disorder, or reading deficiency; and

4. Have previously retired and were a highly effective elementary school teacher based on student reading scores on the statewide English Language Arts assessment or teacher evaluations.

I. If a school district that is prioritized for supports and interventions pursuant to this section declines to accept assistance from a literacy coach, the district shall not be eligible to receive funds pursuant to Section 1210.508D of this title.

J. 1. School districts shall have a minimum of one reading specialist, interventionist, or staff member with an early literacy micro-credential for each public elementary school.

2. For school districts who do not currently employ or contract with a reading specialist or interventionist, the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability, in collaboration with the State Department of Education, shall work with public or private

1 institutions of higher education within this state to develop
2 teacher training academies for teachers to obtain an early literacy
3 micro-credential. The academies shall provide a competency-based
4 professional learning micro-credential after completing an intensive
5 teacher training academy held at Oklahoma-based universities.

6 3. The teacher training academies developed pursuant to
7 paragraph 2 of this subsection may include in-person instruction,
8 synchronous online, or hybrid options. The intensive academy shall
9 be focused on MTSS, the science of reading, and standards alignment
10 for early literacy instruction in kindergarten through third grade.
11 Districts shall select at least one staff member per school, with
12 priority given to districts without a current full- or part-time
13 reading specialist or interventionist, per year to attend the
14 teacher training academies. These individuals can be teachers and
15 full- or part-time interventionists who will work with students in
16 kindergarten through third grade.

17 4. The Office of Educational Quality and Accountability shall
18 set program criteria for the micro-credential course and vet higher
19 education programs seeking to issue the credential to Oklahoma
20 educators. The Commission for Educational Quality and
21 Accountability shall approve higher education institutions allowed
22 to issue an early literacy micro-credential. Both public and
23 private higher education institutions may apply.
24

1 5. Instructors for teacher training academies shall possess
2 relevant field experience, including demonstrated recent practice in
3 the field.

4 6. The State Department of Education shall fund a stipend of
5 Three Thousand Dollars (\$3,000.00) for up to one staff member per
6 school serving students in kindergarten through third grade to
7 attend and receive an early literacy micro-credential. The
8 Department shall fund any public or private higher education
9 institution approved by the Commission for Educational Quality and
10 Accountability with One Thousand Five Hundred Dollars (\$1,500.00)
11 per kindergarten through third grade staff member that attends and
12 receives an early literacy micro-credential.

13 ~~E.~~ K. The State Department of Education shall electronically
14 submit a report to the Governor, the President Pro Tempore of the
15 Senate, and the Speaker of the House of Representatives by December
16 31, 2026, that includes an evaluation of the pilot program by school
17 districts, data on whether the program had an impact on increasing
18 the number of students who demonstrate proficiency in reading, and
19 recommendations for changes to the Strong Readers Act.

20 SECTION 9. NEW LAW A new section of law to be codified
21 in the Oklahoma Statutes as Section 1210.508J of Title 70, unless
22 there is created a duplication in numbering, reads as follows:

23 A. There is hereby created in the State Treasury a revolving
24 fund for the State Department of Education to be designated the

1 "Strong Readers Revolving Fund". The fund shall be a continuing
2 fund, not subject to fiscal year limitations, and shall consist of
3 all monies received by the State Department of Education from
4 private businesses, nonprofit organizations, and federally
5 recognized Indian tribes or nations. All monies accruing to the
6 credit of the fund are hereby appropriated and may be budgeted and
7 expended by the State Department of Education for the purpose of
8 improving reading outcomes in accordance with the Strong Readers
9 Act. Expenditures from the fund shall be made upon warrants issued
10 by the State Treasurer against claims filed as prescribed by law
11 with the Director of the Office of Management and Enterprise
12 Services for approval and payment.

13 B. Donors to the Strong Readers Revolving Fund shall designate
14 a specific school, school district, or region to receive their
15 donation. The State Department of Education shall distribute monies
16 from the Strong Readers Revolving Fund in strict compliance with
17 donor designations required by this subsection.

18 C. Monies in the Strong Readers Revolving Fund may be expended
19 for implementation support services, teacher training, data
20 integration, evaluation, reporting, micro-credential stipends and
21 program fees, and professional learning, to support statewide MTSS
22 implementation goals.

23 SECTION 10. It being immediately necessary for the preservation
24 of the public peace, health or safety, an emergency is hereby

1 declared to exist, by reason whereof this act shall take effect and
2 be in full force from and after its passage and approval.

3 Passed the Senate the 25th day of March, 2026.

4

5

Presiding Officer of the Senate

6

7 Passed the House of Representatives the ____ day of _____,
8 2026.

9

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Presiding Officer of the House
of Representatives

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